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Working From Home and the Output of Patent Examiners: Evidence From a Staggered Rollout

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Abstract. We study a staggered work-from-home rollout in a fictional national patent office. Using case-level data on 2,900 examiners over four years, we find that moving to full-time remote work increased the number of completed examinations by 4.4 percent without a measurable decline in quality, as captured by appeal reversal rates.

Keywords: work from home, productivity, public sector, natural experiment

Kurgusal örnek veri. AI Agents Masterclass (@selma.builds) için üretildi; gerçek bir yayın değildir.

Method

Event-study regressions exploit the different start dates across examination units.

Results

Output rose by 4.4 percent (s.e. 1.1). Effects were largest for examiners with long commutes.

Conclusion

Using case-level data on 2,900 examiners over four years, we find that moving to full-time remote work increased the number of completed examinations by 4.4 percent without a measurable decline in quality, as captured by appeal reversal rates.

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